CHAPTER 32

NEW BEGINNINGS

November 2010

There is a new togetherness with this team. The goals have been marked clearly – we want to do what has not been done for too long – to win in Australia and become the number one Test team in the world. Andy Flower and Andrew Strauss have been great for English cricket. They are a really good combination, understanding each other and how to communicate simple and ambitious ideas. This has been a relief to everyone after a real low and nosedive in form before they were appointed. They have marked exactly how we become number one in the world – giving us the exact sequence of results that are required to get us there. We know the games that we need to win, the path that is taking us there. Though the usual gets spouted – taking each game as it comes, not really thinking about anything other than the next day of cricket – we all know the exact long-term plan and have bought into it. Flower is the most straight-talking coach I have experienced. He tells me straight and exactly as he sees it if I've done well or if I've been crap. I find I respond well to this kind of simplicity. There is something that takes a weight off to know exactly where I stand in each moment. It goes for everyone else too – it's a regimented, organised focus that is created – everyone driven to be the best they can be. They make it clear that if we are to achieve what we want to, we need at least a few players in the top ten of the bowling and batting rankings. They have both pulled me aside a number of times and told me that they want me to be leading the attack while this happens – shaping a team in our image and not what has come before.